

APPLICANT HANDBOOK

Guidance for Completing the Ethics Review Application

I. GENERAL INFORMATION

1. Name of the Applicant: Provide the full legal name of the applicant submitting the proposal.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to establish the legal and administrative identity of the individual responsible for the ethics application and subsequent compliance.*

2. Principal Investigator(s): Provide complete professional details of the PI (Name, Position, Affiliation, Domain Expertise, and Email). This establishes responsibility and accountability for ethical conduct.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to identify the individual bearing primary ethical, legal, and institutional responsibility for the conduct of the research and protection of participants.*

3. Co-Investigator(s) (if any): List all co-investigators involved in the study (Name, Position, Affiliation, Domain Expertise, and Email).

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to clarify shared responsibilities, distribution of expertise, and accountability in collaborative research.*

4. Principal Investigator(s) (in case of PhD Research Scholar): Please provide the following details: Full Name, School, Research Domain/Discipline, Year of Study, Official Email ID. If the applicant is a PhD Research Scholar, list the scholar as the Principal Investigator.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this information to clearly identify responsibility for the ethical conduct of the study, establish academic accountability, and enable appropriate communication and monitoring by the REC, particularly for student-led research.*

5. Details of the Co-Investigator(s), if any (in case of PhD Research Scholar)

Provide full details of all co-investigators who will be actively involved in the research. This ensures transparency regarding contributions and accountability for research conduct.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to confirm the roles, expertise, and responsibilities of all personnel involved, ensuring ethical and academic accountability.*

6. Supervisor Details (for PhD Research Scholars): Provide supervisor's name and institutional email address.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure academic oversight and mentorship where the applicant does not hold independent research authority.*

7. CC in Acknowledgement Email: State the name and email address of persons to be copied in the VU-REC acknowledgement email. If left blank, communication will be only with the PI.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to prevent communication gaps and ensure transparency among supervisors, collaborators, and institutional authorities.*

II. RESEARCH OVERVIEW

1. Title of the Research Study: Provide the full official title of the study.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to allow reviewers to identify the scope, intent, and ethical domain of the research at a glance.*

2. Short Title: Provide a concise working title.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to facilitate internal tracking, correspondence, and referencing of the study.*

3. Discipline of Research: (Specify – restricts to a specific discipline / interdisciplinary / multidisciplinary) Clarify the disciplinary positioning of the study.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assign appropriate reviewers and assess discipline-specific ethical standards.*

4. Area(s) of Research: Indicate thematic or subject areas addressed.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to identify sensitive domains, regulatory overlaps, or heightened ethical concerns.*

5. Research Study Summary (Lay Terms) (150–250 words): Explain the study in simple, non-technical language understandable to non-experts.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to confirm that the study can be explained transparently to non-experts and prospective participants.*

6. Explanatory Background and Significance (500–1000 words; include literature references): Describe the academic context, gap, and importance of the study.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ethically justify why the research should be conducted and to ensure it has demonstrable academic or social value.*

7. Research Objectives: List clearly defined objectives.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure clarity of purpose and prevent unnecessary data collection or participant burden.*

8. Research Problem(s): State the research problem(s) being addressed.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to confirm that the research addresses a clearly defined, legitimate, and ethically justifiable problem.*

9. Research Design / Methodology: Describe the overall research approach.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because poorly designed research exposes participants to risk without generating valid knowledge, which is ethically unacceptable.*

10. Type of Research: Specify the type - e.g., anonymous survey, non-sensitive interview, observational study, experimental study, secondary data (no personal identifiers), mixed-methods, publicly available data, no direct human engagement, other

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to determine the applicable ethical standards and the appropriate level of ethics review.*

11. Research Setting: Specify the setting - e.g., university campus, online platform, clinical site

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because context influences privacy, safety, power dynamics, and consent processes.*

12. Site(s) of Research: Specify - Single-centre / Multi-centre

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because multi-site research may require additional permissions and coordinated ethical oversight.*

13. & 14. Number of Sites: Specify number of local and overseas sites.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess scale, logistical complexity, and cross-jurisdictional ethical considerations.*

15. Collaborative Research (if applicable): Provide details of collaborating institutions, investigators, designations, and contact information.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to clarify shared ethical responsibility and jurisdiction across collaborating institutions.*

16. Sampling Strategy: Provide details of sampling strategy (e.g., random, purposive, convenience – specify)

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure participant selection is scientifically justified*

and ethically fair.

17. Tools / Materials / Questionnaires Used: List all instruments and tools.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because tool selection may raise issues of consent, copyright, validity, and academic integrity.*

18. Duration of Research Study: Specify duration in days/months/years.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because longer studies may increase cumulative risk and require ongoing monitoring.*

19. Research Timeline: Provide start and end dates.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess feasibility and plan continuing review or progress reporting.*

20. Preliminary / Pilot Studies: Briefly describe any pilot work relevant to this proposal.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to identify prior participant exposure and inform risk assessment.*

21. Prior Ethics Review: Indicate Yes/No. If yes, provide details and attach approval as annexure.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to prevent duplicate review and identify existing ethical conditions or restrictions.*

22. Ethics Review by Collaborating Institution: Indicate Yes/No and attach approval if applicable.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure harmonisation of ethical oversight in collaborative research.*

23. Approved Research Proposal: Specify submitted as Annexure no. ... / not submitted)

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify that the ethics application aligns with the*

approved scientific protocol.

24. Dissemination of Research Findings: Specify intended dissemination modes (journals, conferences, theses, policy briefs, etc.).

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because ethical research must contribute to knowledge and not remain unpublished without justification.*

25. Sharing Findings with Participants/Communities: Indicate Yes/No.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to promote reciprocity, transparency, and respect toward participants and communities.*

26 (a-c). Plagiarism & AI Detection: Provide details of: a. Plagiarism Percentage Detected; b. AI-generated Content Detected; and c. Approved plagiarism detection software and AI-content detection tools used for detection

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this*
a. to ensure originality and compliance with academic integrity norms.
b. to clarify human intellectual responsibility for research design and interpretation.
c. to ensure the reliability and acceptability of integrity checks.

27. Plagiarism & AI Detection Report: Specify submitted as Annexure no. ... / not submitted)

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to obtain verifiable documentary evidence for ethics certification.*

28. Requested Ethics Review Category: Specify Exempt / Expedited / Full Committee – justify selection

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to allow proportionate review and prevent misclassification of risk.*

29. Stage of study (in case of PhD Research Scholar): Indicate the current stage of your research (e.g., Proposal stage or Data Collection stage). This helps the REC understand the progress of your research.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to evaluate potential risks, timing of ethical oversight, and whether approval is sought for retrospective or prospective work.*

30. RAC approvals for research study and protocol (in case of PhD Research Scholar): Indicate whether your Research Advisory Committee (RAC) has approved the study protocol. Attach any official approval document if applicable.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify that research proposals have undergone internal academic review before ethical review, as RAC approval confirms scientific validity and alignment with institutional research standards.*

III. PARTICIPANTS

1. Subject of Research: Specify- human participants, animals, biological materials, personal/digital data, institutions, communities, environments, AI systems, legal or socio-economic systems, others

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because different subjects trigger different ethical frameworks and protections.*

2. Human Participants: Specify details on the general adult population, students, employees, community members, consumers, key informants, experts, professionals, online participants (digital platforms, social media users), or any other details not mentioned above).

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because participant characteristics directly affect consent, risk, and safeguards.*

3. Ethical Implications – Human Participants: Explain informed consent, privacy, confidentiality, and risk–benefit considerations. Specify details regarding informed consent, privacy, risk-benefit balance, confidentiality, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure risks are identified and managed before recruitment begins.*

4. Vulnerable Populations (if applicable): Specify category details on children and adolescents, elderly (especially dependent or institutionalized), people with cognitive, psychological, or psychiatric vulnerabilities, economically or socially disadvantaged groups, women in sensitive contexts (violence, reproductive rights, discrimination studies, prisoners, detainees, refugees, migrants, displaced person, indigenous and tribal communities) or any other details not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because vulnerability necessitates heightened ethical safeguards.*

5. Safeguards for Vulnerable Populations: Specify details regarding additional safeguards, assent + consent, power dynamics, culturally appropriate protection, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to confirm that additional protections are actively implemented.*

6. Communities/Groups as Subjects: Specify details on cultural communities, religious or ethnic groups, villages/neighbourhoods, urban communities, professional communities (e.g., lawyers, gig workers, doctors), online communities or networks) or any other details not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because group-level harms may occur even when individuals consent.*

7. Ethical Implications–(Communities/Groups): Specify details regarding community consent/gatekeeper approvals/permission processes and approvals, protection from stigma, misrepresentation, or harm at the group level, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to protect against stigma, misrepresentation, and collective harm.*

8. Organisations and Institutions as Subjects: Specify details on Universities/Schools/Corporations/startups/Government departments/ NGOs/civil society bodies/Healthcare or policing units or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because institutional permissions and confidentiality obligations differ from individual consent.*

9. Ethical Implications–(Organisations and Institutions): Specify details regarding institutional permission, confidentiality of organisational data, conflict of interest management, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to prevent misuse of organisational data and conflicts of interest.*

10. Animals as Subjects: Specify animal type. Specify details on laboratory animals/farm animals/wild animals/ecological research subjects, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because animal research is governed by separate statutory ethical standards.*

11. Ethical Implications–(Animals): Specify details regarding Animal Ethics Committee approvals, humane treatment, replacement, reduction, refinement, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure humane treatment and regulatory compliance.*

12. Biological Materials/Specimen: Specify type, approvals, and annexures. Specify details on human biological samples (blood, saliva, tissue, urine, DNA), stored clinical samples/biobank materials, animal tissues and biological specimens, Trial Registration Number - attach, Regulatory Approvals – attach, or any other details not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because biological materials raise consent, ownership, and future-use concerns.*

13. Ethical Implications–(Biological Materials): Specify details regarding biobank consent, secondary use – disclose source of data and attach permission letter, genetic privacy, data-sharing governance, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to protect genetic privacy and govern secondary use.*

14. Data as Participants/Data Subjects: Specify details on personal data (student records, employment records, health data), sensitive data (genetic, biometric, sexual, caste, religion, disability), digital footprints (social media, browsing patterns, platform usage), administrative datasets and institutional databases or any other details not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because data can cause harm even without direct human interaction.*

15. Ethical Implications – (Data): Specify details regarding Data protection laws, anonymisation, consent for reuse, cybersecurity safeguards, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure compliance with data protection and privacy laws.*

16. Digital/AI/Technological Entities: Specify AI systems, algorithms, platforms, or virtual entities. Specify details on AI systems being evaluated, algorithms interacting with users, robots in human-interaction experiments, UX testing platforms involving user engagement, virtual environment participants (avatars representing real people), or any other details not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this*

because emerging technologies introduce novel ethical risks.

17. Ethical Implications–(Digital / AI Systems): Explain transparency, fairness, bias mitigation, and harm prevention. Specify details regarding human impact, transparency, fairness, algorithmic bias safeguards, harm-prevention, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to address bias, opacity, and unintended harm.*

18. Cultural, Visual, and Creative Subjects: Specify images, recordings, artefacts, artworks, installations. Specify what will be part of the research - images of people, voices and video recordings, cultural artefacts, artworks, symbols, public installations and visual design research participants, any other details not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because visual and cultural materials can expose identity and dignity.*

19. Ethical Implications-(Cultural/Visual Subjects): Explain consent, ownership, dignity, and misrepresentation safeguards. Specify details regarding Consent for use, ownership, dignity, misrepresentation safeguards, or any other information not mentioned above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure consent, respect, and protection from misrepresentation.*

20. Sample Size: Specify number of participants.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because excessive samples increase risk while insufficient samples undermine validity.*

21. Sample Size Justification: Provide scientific justification.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because ethical research must also be scientifically adequate.*

22. & 23. Dependent Relationship: Indicate Yes/No and provide details if yes.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because power relationships may compromise voluntariness.*

24. Voluntariness in Institutional Relationships:

When research involves participants who have an academic or employment relationship with Vidyashilp University, applicants must demonstrate clear and proactive measures that support voluntary participation and protect freedom of choice.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that participation by students, colleagues, or employees is based on free and informed choice, without real or perceived pressure arising from institutional, academic, or professional relationships.*

25. Age Range: Specify lower and upper age limits.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because age affects consent capacity and vulnerability.*

26. Participant Information Sheet: Specify submitted as Annexure no. ... / not submitted

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because participants must receive clear and complete study information.*

27. & 28. Research Visits: Specify frequency, number, and duration of visits.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because visit frequency and duration influence burden and risk.*

29. Difficulties and Limitations: Discuss anticipated challenges.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess realistic planning and ethical foresight.*

30. Alternative Approaches: Describe alternatives to achieve aims.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because ethical review favour less risky means to achieve the same aims.*

IV. RECRUITMENT PROCESS

1. Recruitment Process Description: Explain where and how potential participants will be identified, approached, and invited to participate.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that participants are identified and approached in an ethical, transparent manner, free from coercion, deception, or undue influence.*

2. Recruitment Materials: Submit copies of advertisements, posters, emails, messages, or announcements. Specify submitted as Annexure no. ... / not submitted.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify that recruitment materials present accurate information, do not exaggerate benefits or understate risks, minimise risks appropriately, and respect participant dignity.*

4. Inclusion Criteria: Clearly state eligibility requirements.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to confirm that participant selection is scientifically justified and aligned with the research objectives.*

5. Exclusion Criteria: Clearly state grounds for exclusion.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because exclusions must be ethically and scientifically justified, particularly where exclusion may relate to vulnerability or risk.*

6. Recruitment Restrictions: Explain any restrictions.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to*

identify legal, institutional, cultural, or contextual limitations that may affect participant access, consent, or fairness.

7. Fairness and Non-Discrimination: Explain how participant selection is equitable and justified.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to uphold the ethical principle of justice by ensuring equitable selection of participants and avoiding unjustified discrimination.*

8. Avoiding Over-Burdening: Describe safeguards to avoid repeatedly recruiting vulnerable or easily accessible populations.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to prevent repeated or excessive recruitment of populations that may be convenient to access but ethically vulnerable to exploitation.*

9. Reimbursement: Specify whether participants will receive reimbursement or compensation.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that compensation does not constitute undue inducement and does not compromise voluntary participation.*

V. CONSENT

1. Requirement of Consent: Indicate Yes/No and justify.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to determine whether participant autonomy is respected and whether any ethical justification exists for not obtaining informed consent.*

2. Type of Consent: Specify Written/Verbal/Digital/Online.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because different modes of consent involve different levels of documentation, traceability, and risk to participants.*

3. Consent Procedure Summary: Describe how consent will be explained and documented.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that consent is a process (not merely a form) and that participants are given adequate time and information to decide freely.*

4. Assent for Minors: Indicate Yes/No and justify.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this children and minors require age-appropriate assent in addition to legally valid consent from parents or guardians.*

5. Language(s) of Consent Documents: Specify all languages used.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that participants are able to understand the information provided in a language they are comfortable with.*

6. & 7. Obtaining Consent: Specify how and by whom consent will be obtained.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess whether the consent process ensures comprehension, voluntariness, and freedom from pressure, particularly where consent is obtained by persons in authority or within dependent relationships.*

8. Consent Form Submission: Specify submitted as Annexure no. ... / not submitted

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify that all required elements of informed consent are clearly, accurately, and adequately addressed.*

9. -11. Assent Documents: Specify language, process, and personnel.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because assent materials must be developmentally and linguistically appropriate for minors, ensure that minors are meaningfully involved in the decision to participate, and prevent undue influence by authority*

figures or caregivers.

12. Assent Form Submission: Specify submitted as Annexure no. ... / not submitted

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify that the assent process respects the minor's understanding, willingness, and capacity to agree.*

13. Audio/Video/Electronic Recording: Indicate Yes (justify) / No.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because recording increases risks related to privacy, confidentiality, and participant identifiability.*

14. Exclusion Due to Recording Refusal: Indicate Yes/No and justify.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess whether refusal to be recorded leads to unjust exclusion, coercion, or compromised voluntariness.*

15. Justification for using recorded portions

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that recording is scientifically necessary and ethically proportionate.*

16. Alternative if recording is declined

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because ethical research should offer reasonable alternatives wherever possible to respect participant choice.*

17. & 18. Withdrawal Rights: Explain withdrawal process and cite consent clause.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that participants retain the right to withdraw without penalty or loss of benefits, and that withdrawal rights are explicitly stated and practically enforceable.*

19. & 20. Deception or Incomplete Disclosure: Indicate Yes/No and justify purpose. If Yes, explain: - Why full disclosure is not possible - How risks are minimised - Whether and how debriefing will occur - Why no non-deceptive alternative exists

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because deception undermines informed consent and is ethically permissible only under strict conditions, must be scientifically necessary, minimal in risk, ethically defensible, and used only when no acceptable non-deceptive alternative exists, with participant welfare protected and debriefing provided.*

21. Re-consent in case of modifications or extended use

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because participants have the right to make an informed decision again if study conditions materially change.*

22. – 24. Justification for waiver of consent: Provide justification addressing minimal risk, rights and welfare, practicability, and voluntariness.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because consent waivers are exceptional, permitted only when risks to participants are minimal, established ethical criteria are met, and participant rights and welfare are not compromised.*

VI. DATA MANAGEMENT

1. Nature of Data/Methodology: Indicate the category that best describes the nature of data and research methodology. Specify Biomedical or Clinical Trial/Social or Behavioural Research/Data-Only or Secondary Data/ Community-based Participatory Research or Emergency / Disaster Research.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this information to determine the applicable ethical standards, regulatory requirements, and level of data*

protection needed for your study.

2. Types of Data Collected: Specify whether data will be identifiable, coded, or fully anonymous.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess the degree of identifiability and the corresponding risks to participant privacy.*

3. & 4. Identifiable Data Collected: Write Yes or No; if yes, provide justification. List all personal identifiers to be collected, if any.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this because identifiable data poses a higher risk of harm if disclosed or misused. VU-REC requires disclosure of personal data elements to ensure that only data essential to the research objectives is collected.*

5. Retention Period for Data Recordings: Specify the duration for which recordings will be retained.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that personal data is not retained longer than ethically or legally justified.*

6. Disposal of Data: Describe the method of secure disposal after retention period.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this information to confirm that data will be permanently and securely destroyed after the approved retention period.*

7. Audio/Video Data Storage and Disposal: Specify secure storage location and disposal plan.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this detail because audio and video recordings increase the risk of participant identification.*

8. Use of Recorded Information: Explain how recordings will be analysed or used in the research.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that recordings are used strictly for the purposes approved under this ethics clearance.*

9. Publication of Recorded Information: Specify whether recordings will be published with or without identifiers.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this disclosure to assess whether publication could compromise participant confidentiality or dignity.*

10. Data Storage Plan: Provide details of physical/digital location, security, and encryption.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify that appropriate technical and organisational safeguards are in place to prevent unauthorised access.*

11. Data Access and Custodianship: Specify who owns, accesses, and manages the data.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to clearly establish data ownership, define authorised access and custodial responsibility, ensure accountability across the research team, and prevent unauthorised access, misuse, or mismanagement of research data.*

12. Data Protection Measures: Explain privacy, confidentiality, and compliance safeguards. Describe technical and administrative safeguards in place.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC asks this to ensure that reasonable and proportionate measures are implemented to protect participant data.*

13. Privacy and Confidentiality Protocol: Explain how participant privacy and confidentiality will be protected.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this explanation to confirm that participant privacy and confidentiality are actively safeguarded throughout the study.*

14. Data Breach Protocol: Describe response, participant notification, and corrective actions.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC asks this to ensure that appropriate corrective and notification*

procedures are in place in the event of a data breach.

15. Data on Withdrawal: Clarify whether previously collected data will be retained or destroyed.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this clarification to ensure that participants' rights on withdrawal are respected without penalty.*

16. Post-Research Data Use: Explain future use of data.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to prevent unauthorised secondary use of data beyond the approved research purposes.*

17. Duration of Data Retention: Specify timelines including recordings.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this information to confirm that data retention periods are justified, finite, and compliant with applicable norms.*

18. Data Sharing Plans: Specify if and how data will be shared.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess whether proposed data sharing maintains participant confidentiality and consent conditions.*

19. & 20. Data Publication Plans: Specify publication intentions. Specify whether published data will identify participants.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this information to evaluate the ethical implications of data dissemination. VU-REC asks this to ensure that identifiable publication occurs only with explicit and informed participant consent.*

21. Compliance with Data Protection Laws: Provide applicable legal compliance details.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires confirmation of legal compliance as part of its institutional and regulatory responsibility.*

22. Use of Archived/Existing Databases: Provide permissions and documentation, if applicable.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC asks this to verify*

that secondary data use is ethically authorised and legally permitted.

23. Use of AI in Research: Indicate Yes/No.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this disclosure because AI systems may introduce risks related to bias, opacity, and accountability.*

24. Name of AI Tool/Software: Specify the AI system used, if applicable.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to identify tool-specific ethical, legal, and data governance implications.*

25. Purpose of Using AI: Explain the specific function of AI in the research.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this information to ensure that AI use is limited, transparent, and scientifically justified.*

26. Transparency, Explainability, and Bias Mitigation: Describe safeguards for fairness, accountability, and transparency.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC asks this to ensure that algorithmic processes do not result in unfair, opaque, or harmful outcomes.*

27. Any Other Remarks: Provide additional relevant information not covered above.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC provides this space to allow disclosure of additional data governance considerations relevant to ethical review.*

VII. RISK–BENEFIT ASSESSMENT

1. Describe potential risks: Identify and describe all foreseeable risks, including physical, psychological, social, legal, privacy (data), or any other relevant risks.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that all potential harms to participants are identified, acknowledged, and considered prior to*

study approval.

2. Risk level: Specify whether the overall risk level of the study is no or minimal risk, low risk, or more than minimal risk.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to determine the appropriate level of ethics review and oversight required for the study.*

3. Mitigation measures: Describe the concrete steps that will be taken to minimise or manage the identified risks.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to confirm that risks are not only recognised but are actively reduced to the lowest possible level.*

4. Anticipated direct benefits to participants: Specify any direct benefits that participants may reasonably expect from taking part in the research.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess whether participants are exposed to risk in return for meaningful or proportionate benefit.*

5. Anticipated indirect or societal benefits: Describe the broader academic, social, policy, or community benefits expected from the research.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that the research has sufficient social or scientific value to ethically justify participant involvement.*

6. Risk–Benefit Justification: Provide a reasoned explanation demonstrating that the anticipated benefits outweigh the identified risks.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to determine whether the overall balance of risk and benefit is ethically acceptable for approval.*

VIII. FINANCIAL ASPECTS / REIMBURSEMENT

1. Declaration of Grants/Funding: Indicate whether the research is receiving any grants or funding by writing Yes or No.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to identify external financial influences that may affect study design, conduct, or reporting.*

2. Source of Grant/Funding: Specify the name of the grant or fund and the institution providing it, if applicable.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess the independence of the research and identify any sponsor-related ethical concerns.*

3. Amount of Sponsorship/Grant: State the total amount of sponsorship or grant received in INR.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to understand the scale of funding and its potential influence on research conduct.*

4. Status of Grant: Applicant to state: Specify whether the grant is approved, pending, or not applicable, and indicate annexure submission if relevant.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify funding legitimacy and ensure transparency at the time of ethics review.*

5. Responsibility for Research-Related Costs: Identify who will bear the costs associated with conducting the research.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that financial responsibilities are clearly defined and ethically appropriate.*

6. Sponsor-Borne Costs (if applicable): List the specific research-related costs that will be covered by the sponsor.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to determine whether sponsor involvement could influence participant safety or research integrity.*

7. Distribution of Funds in Collaborative Research: Disclose how funds or grants will be distributed among collaborating institutions or investigators.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure transparency and prevent financial conflicts in collaborative arrangements.*

8. Payment to Research Participants: Indicate whether participants will receive payment and provide details, or state “No reimbursement.”

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that payments do not constitute undue inducement or compromise voluntary participation.*

9. Student Course Credits for Participation: Indicate whether student participants will receive course credits, or state “No reimbursement.”

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess whether academic incentives may unduly influence students’ decision to participate.*

10. Financial or Other Benefits to Researchers or Institution: Declare any financial or other benefits to the PI, Co-Investigators, School, or Institution arising from the study.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to identify and manage undue influence, potential conflicts of interest that may affect objectivity or participant welfare.*

IX. CONFLICT OF INTEREST DECLARATION

1. No Conflict of Interest Exists: Indicate whether any conflict of interest exists by writing Yes or No.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to obtain an explicit declaration regarding the absence or presence of conflicts that may influence the research.*

2. Conflict of Interest Exists: If Yes, specify the nature of the conflict of interest and the measures proposed to manage or mitigate it.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to ensure that identified conflicts are transparently disclosed and adequately managed to protect research integrity and participant interests.*

X. ANNEXURE CHECKLIST

1. Mandatory Annexures: Tick all applicable annexures submitted with this application and clearly indicate the corresponding annexure numbers.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to verify that all required supporting documents are provided for a complete and accurate ethics review.*

2. List of Documents Not Submitted: List any required annexures not submitted and provide a brief justification for their absence.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to assess whether missing documents affect the ethical adequacy of the application or require conditional approval.*

XI. DECLARATION BY THE RESEARCHER

Sign declarations of originality and compliance.

Why VU-REC asks this: *VU-REC requires this to establish formal accountability, ensure researcher responsibility for ethical compliance, and create a legally and institutionally binding record of commitment to responsible research conduct.*

GENERAL INSTRUCTIONS FOR APPLICANTS:

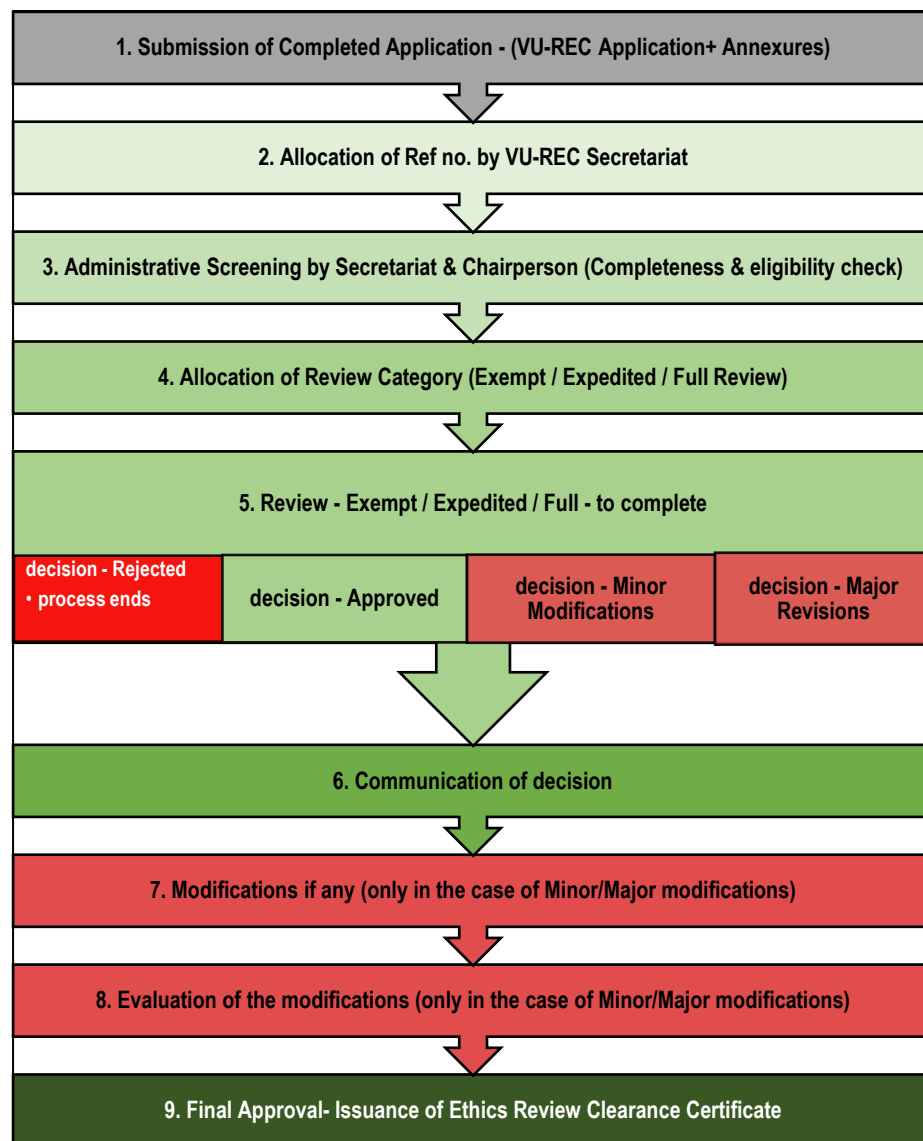
1. Ethical review timelines are determined solely by the Research Ethics Committee (REC). Applicants shall not presume or request expedited review based on academic urgency, submission deadlines, or programme milestones.

2. Late-stage submission of an ethics application by a PhD Research Scholar does not entitle the applicant to fast-tracked review. Ethical approval shall not be presumed on the basis of delayed intimation, supervisory timelines, or academic requirements.
3. Ethical approval is strictly prospective. Any data collected prior to formal REC approval shall be considered unauthorised and cannot be legitimised retrospectively.
4. PhD Research Scholars, in consultation with their Supervisor(s), shall intimate the REC regarding the proposed data-collection protocol once the research design and data-collection methodology have received academic approval from the Research Advisory Committee (RAC).
5. PhD Research Scholars, in consultation with their Supervisor(s), must obtain REC approval prior to commencing any pilot study or full-scale data collection involving human participants, personal data, or sensitive materials.

GENERAL INSTRUCTIONS FOR APPLICATION SUBMISSION:

1. Ensure that no fields are left blank.
2. Where a question does not apply, clearly state “Not applicable.”
3. Annexure numbers must be specified wherever annexures are requested in the application form.
4. Confirm that all required annexures have been uploaded before final submission.
5. Refer to the REC work cycle before making submissions.
6. Submissions are encouraged to be made online only. (Digital signatures are encouraged wherever required. In the absence of digital signatures, applicants shall submit a scanned copy of the application bearing the signatures of all concerned parties.)
7. Incomplete applications may be returned without review.

Ethical Review Process



Box 1 — Application Submission (Applicant)

Submission of completed **VU-REC Application Form** with all required annexures. (Wait for administrative screening)

Box 2 — Reference Number Allocation (VU-REC Secretary)

Allocation of **VU-REC Reference Number**

Box 3 — Administrative Screening (VU-REC Secretary & Chairperson) -Screening for completeness, eligibility, required signatures, and annexures- *Incomplete* → *Rejected* - *Return to applicant (process ends)* *Complete* → *Proceed*

Box 4 — Review Category Allocation (VU-REC Secretary & Chairperson)-Classification of application as: **Exempt / Expedited / Full Committee Review**

Box 5 — Ethical Review (VU-REC / Reviewers) - Ethical review conducted as per assigned category (Exempt review-Expedited review-Full Review)

— **REC Decision:** Decision recorded as one of the following:

- **Approved** → **Proceed to Box 9**
- **Approved with Minor Modifications** → **Proceed to Box 7**
- **Major Modifications Required** → **Proceed to Box 7**
- **Rejected** → **Process Ends**

Box 6 — Communication of Decision (VU-REC Secretary) - Formal communication of decision to applicant

Box 7 — Submission of Modifications (Applicant – if applicable) - Revised documents and point-wise response submitted (*only for Minor / Major Modifications*)

Box 8 — Review of Modifications (VU-REC) - Evaluation of revised submission.

Box 9— Final Approval - Issuance of **Ethics Review Clearance Certificate** (Approval is prospective from date of issue)

Possible Outcomes of Ethical Review

1. Approved

An ethics application may be approved when:

- The research complies with all applicable ethical principles, institutional policies, and legal requirements.
- Risks to participants are minimal or adequately mitigated.
- Informed consent procedures are clear, appropriate, and proportionate.
- Provisions for confidentiality, data protection, and participant welfare are adequate.
- The research design is scientifically sound and ethically justifiable.
- All required approvals (e.g., RAC approval, where applicable) are in place.

What the decision mean for the Applicant:

- *Ethics approval is granted.*
- *The Ethics Review Clearance Certificate is issued.*
- *Data collection may commence only from the date of approval.*

2. Approved with Minor Modifications

An ethics application may be approved with minor modifications when:

- The study is ethically acceptable in principle, but
- Minor clarifications or corrections are required, such as:
 - Wording changes in the Participant Information Sheet or Consent Form
 - Minor additions to risk mitigation or data handling descriptions
 - Clarification of procedures without altering study design
 - Formatting or administrative corrections

What the decision mean for the Applicant:

- *Modifications do not change the core design or risk profile of the study.*
- *No further full REC deliberation is required.*
- *Applicant must submit revised documents addressing the REC's comments.*
- *Approval is issued after verification by the designated reviewer.*

3. Major Modifications Required

An ethics application may be deferred with major modifications when:

- Substantive ethical concerns are identified that can potentially be addressed, such as:
 - Inadequate risk–benefit justification
 - Significant gaps in consent procedures
 - Insufficient safeguards for vulnerable participants
 - Unclear or problematic data protection measures
 - Methodological issues affecting participant safety or fairness

What the decision mean for the Applicant:

- *Changes required affect the substance of the study, not just wording.*
- *May require:*
 - *Revised protocol*
 - *Revised consent process*
 - *Additional safeguards or oversight*
- *No approval is granted at this stage.*
- *A revised application must be submitted for further review.*
- *Data collection must not commence until approval is granted.*

2. Rejected

An ethics application may be rejected when:

- The study involves unacceptable or immitigable risk to participants.
- Ethical approval is sought retrospectively after data collection has begun or been completed.
- The research design is fundamentally unethical or scientifically invalid.
- The application shows serious misrepresentation, non-disclosure, or lack of transparency.
- The applicant fails to adequately respond to major ethical concerns raised by the REC.
- The study violates institutional policy, legal requirements, or ethical standards.

What the decision mean for the Applicant:

- *Ethical approval cannot be granted for the submitted protocol.*
- *Modifications would require a fundamental redesign of the study.*
- *The application process for that protocol ends.*
- *A substantially redesigned study may be submitted as a new application, subject to fresh review.*

Categories of Ethical Review

1. Exempt Review

An ethics application may be classified as *Exempt* when:

- The research involves minimal or no risk to participants.
- The study uses non-identifiable, anonymised, or publicly available data.
- No interaction or intervention with human participants is involved.
- The research does not involve vulnerable populations, sensitive topics, or personal data.
- Data are analysed in aggregate form with no possibility of re-identification.

Examples:

- Analysis of fully anonymised secondary datasets.
- Research using publicly available documents or datasets.
- Programme evaluations or audits with no personal identifiers.

Review Process:

- Reviewed by the Chairperson and Secretary and by a designated REC member.
- No full committee deliberation required.

2. Expedited Review

An ethics application may be classified as *Expedited* when:

- The research involves minimal risk, but
- Includes limited interaction with participants or collection of identifiable data.
- Procedures are non-invasive and routine.
- Potential harms are minor, reversible, and adequately mitigated.
- The study does not involve highly vulnerable populations or sensitive interventions.

Examples:

- Surveys or interviews on non-sensitive topics.
- Minimal-risk behavioural or educational research.
- Collection of identifiable data with robust confidentiality safeguards.

Review Process:

- Reviewed by the Chairperson and Secretary and two or more designated reviewers.
- Faster than full review, but still involves ethical scrutiny.

3. Full Committee Review

An ethics application requires *Full Review* when:

- The research involves more than minimal risk to participants.
- Vulnerable populations are involved (e.g., children, persons with diminished autonomy).
- The study involves sensitive topics (e.g., mental health, trauma, sexuality, illegal activities).
- There are invasive procedures, deception, or significant psychological or social risk.
- Data security, consent, or risk mitigation issues require collective deliberation.
- There is potential for serious ethical, legal, or reputational implications.

Examples:

- Clinical or interventional studies.
- Mental health or trauma-related research.
- Studies involving deception or manipulation.
- Research involving sensitive personal or health data.

Review Process:

- Reviewed by the full REC during a convened meeting.
- Decisions recorded in formal minutes.